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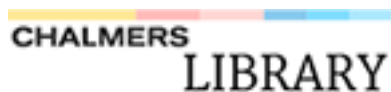
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Film tourism: sustained economic contributions to destinations

Film tourism

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to highlight the potential of film-induced tourism to provide sustained economic contribution to destinations.

Design/methodology/approach – The paper takes the form of a literature review and identifies the economic contribution made by film-induced tourism.

Findings – It is observed that film-induced tourism only provides a sustained economic contribution to destinations in exceptional circumstances.

Practical implications – Destinations need to incorporate film as a functional component of their management. Managers need to focus on the subtle roles film plays in destination awareness, motivation, and image and expectation formation. This focus is best deployed in connecting film audiences with the destination, and tourist experiences available.

Originality/value – The paper questions the emphasis placed on film as a tourism-inducing agent and at same time, illustrates that film has a subtle influence and this requires further emphasis by destination managers.

Keywords Tourism, Film, Consumer behaviour

Paper type Viewpoint

Film tourism, and the broader area of tourism and the media, has grown as an area of academic popularity as evidenced by journal special issues (for example: *Tourism Culture and Communication*, 6(3), 2006; *Tourist Studies*, 6(1), 2006; *Tourism Analysis*, 14(2), 2009; *Tourism Review International*, 13(2), 2009; and *Tourism and Hospitality Planning and Development*, 7(1), 2010). This growing popularity has been perceived to reflect a dramatically increased scale of film-induced tourism. However, this is not the case, instead the popularity can in part be attributed to the “sexiness” of the topic area, though is also to the greater recognised role of media in contemporary society, and consequently the role of media in tourism.

Whilst earlier papers noted a relationship between tourism and the media (Boorstin, 1961; Curtis, 1981), it was Butler’s (1990) discussion of the influence of the media in shaping international tourist patterns that specifically recognised a role of media in tourism. Butler (1990) further forecasted the increasing role of the film image in tourism demand and visitation. Indeed, in the early 1990s cases were noting the influence of movies on site visitation (Riley and Van Doreen, 1992). Movies were not the only area of media being investigated, also were guidebooks (Lew, 1991), fiction books (Squire, 1993), and television (Tooke and Baker, 1996). In these sources, representation of people and places, and visitation to these places were the focus of investigation, and these two themes still dominate the media discussions in the tourism literature. More generally, the current discussions of tourism and media commonly fit into either functional perspective (the functional use and management of media in tourism roles, such as marketing, attractions, and development), or into a critical perspective (the critique of the media for its representations of places, people, and cultures in and for tourism).



Through both of these themes, of function and critique, there has been an emphasis on the positive and negative influences of the media on tourism; the influence of film on perceptions and visitation, and the influence of film tourists. In these two themes, I take a functional perspective, investigating the role of film in broader tourist decision making, and the influence and management of this process. Primarily, I see the image as the focus to manage the influence of film on tourism, and especially the use of film images to align potential tourists to the destination's ideal image. This perspective is not negating the powerful influence of film in creating and reinforcing representations.

In this context, I will provide my insights to what contribution film-induced tourism will make in securing sustained economic growth in a tourist destination. Note, these responses are informed by a number of sources, though most often I will refer to my own writing in which I have synthesised these ideas. Film, for the case of this discussion, includes movies, television, and the like. In these, there is an implied emphasis on fictional film, though non-fiction film, such as documentaries are also relevant. An initial response is that film induced tourism specifically would only make a limited economic contribution, and the contribution would not be sustainable. All the same, the potential contribution of film-induced tourism, and its sustainability is dependent on many factors.

The initial response is based upon the exceptional role of films to actually induce visitation (Croy and Heitmann, 2011). A point to clarify is that film-induced tourism has an inherent cause-and-effect relationship, watching the film induces visitation to the filmed place. There is a huge range of films, though only a very small number have an identified impact on visitation (Croy and Walker, 2003). Further to this, some of those with an identified role, such as *The Lord of the Rings*, actually do not induce much tourism at all (Croy, 2010). As such, it is the exception, rather than the rule, when a film does induce tourism. Nonetheless, films influence activities and routes when at the destination (Macionis and Sparks, 2009), and whilst films are incidental, they are a tourist activity (Croy and Buchmann, 2009). This activity provides the opportunity for film to contribute economically to a destination. If the film activity is a competitor for, or an extension to tourist time and expenditure has not been established, therefore if film tourism contributes to a destination is unclear.

Further to the tourism inducing nature of film, there are also many travel barriers, relevant to all tourism. Barriers can include resource availability, such as time and money, the accessibility of the destination, such as visa control and transport, and travel party desire, specifically, do the other decision makers want to visit the filmed destination. As such, a destination's ability to capitalise on film created visitation desires may be hindered by its location. Overall, it may be concluded that only in exceptional circumstances film-induced tourism would make a sustained economic contribution to a destination.

If broadening the inquiry to film tourism, from film-induced tourism, there is greater scope to identify sustained economic impact to a destination. This is also where I would suggest a destination's focus should be when considering the potential impacts of film on tourism. The distinction between film tourism and film-induced tourism is subtle, but important. Film-induced tourism is the role of film as an attractor, motivator, and demanded experience for the tourist. The film tourism studies indicate that film is largely an incidental tourist experience (Macionis and Sparks, 2009; Croy, 2010), and the number of purposeful film tourists is in fact very small (Croy and Heitmann, 2011).

Film tourism allows for a greater inclusion of the many roles and relationships of film and tourism to be investigated, beyond a direct cause-and-effect relationship. Unfortunately, with the broadening scope, the ability to identify specific film tourism economic impacts is diluted.

Taking the broader approach of film tourism, we assess the functional roles of film in tourism, and focuses on maximising the positive desired impacts from these. Film has important pre-visit roles, including in destination awareness, image formation, expectation creation, and destination decision making (Croy and Walker, 2003; Croy, 2010; Croy and Heitmann, 2011). The opportunities of film, for any destination, are the characteristics of film itself:

- audiences choose to watch film;
- film engages the audience to personalise the story;
- film has celebrated and adored people acting the parts;
- film is picture perfect;
- film is distributed internationally;
- film is distributed through numerous means (theatres, Blu-Ray, pay-per-view, pay TV, TV, and internet);
- film is talked about in social circles and discussed in the media; and
- film is desired, credible, and memorable.

These characteristics further emphasis the pre-visit role of film and the potential of focusing on these roles. The other overriding characteristic of film, for the destination, is that all of the above is at no direct expense to the destination. These characteristics should also draw attention to the need for a very active destination management organisation, as the influence of film can very quickly and easily overwrite non-strategic actions of the destination. Imagine a destination promotion competing against a film – promotions are generally undesired, not credible, and unmemorable. Linking back to the economic contribution, the value of film production at a destination is generally valuable, and often the sole reason why film productions are desired by places (Croy and Walker, 2003), and even induced through tax breaks and the like (Hudson and Ritchie, 2006). The promotion and distribution of the film is at no direct cost to the destination. Of course, this is taking a one-dimensional view of economic impacts, without considering the benefits and costs to society, the environment, or opportunities lost. Superficially, film production has mitigated costs to the destination, whilst a number of benefits (Croy and Walker, 2003).

Can a film make a sustained economic contribution to the destination after screening? There is the potential for many post-production effects (PPEs), and some of these can be directly attributed to films (for example, film-induced tourists and film tour businesses). Other PPEs may be much harder to identify (for example, awareness, image, expectation, and decision changes), and as such the influence on economic contributions will be even harder to measure. The role for the destination management organisation is therefore to manage these pre-visit film influences to maximise the desired and positive benefits for the destination (Croy, 2010). For awareness to be enhanced, the film needs to be linked to the destination, and in most film cases this is not an automatic happening. For example, *The Lord of the Rings* is set in a mythical land of Middle Earth,

more representational of an older Europe, as per J.R.R. Tolkien's research interests. All the same, Middle Earth and *The Lord of the Rings* is now associated with New Zealand, much to the efforts of Tourism New Zealand linking the films to the country (Croy, 2010). Awareness is also the first step of a destination selection process; unaware destinations are automatically excluded from the process (Woodside and Sherrell, 1977). A number of methods to link film to place have been presented (Croy and Walker, 2003; Hudson and Ritchie, 2006), and importance should be placed on the more credible and celebrated means first (Smith and Croy, 2005; Croy, 2010). For example, (hosted) journalists' reports on filming locations, and the well-known actors, directors, and the like prompted to report on their location experiences.

The films, complemented by these perceived unbiased reports by journalists and celebrities, help create an image of the destination, and through increased exposure, the image becomes more familiar (Smith and Croy, 2005; Croy and Wheeler, 2007; Moyle and Croy, 2009; Croy, 2010). Importantly, again to link the image to a place, and to make sure it is a desired and realistic image created (Moyle and Croy, 2009), these exposures should direct potential tourists to a controlled information distribution, specifically the destination's web site. Through the media and web site, the film image can be created (pre-film) or modified (post-film) to align with the destination, and most importantly with the community's desired inclusive image of the destination (Croy and Buchmann, 2009; Croy and Heitmann, 2011). The media stories from journalists, actors, and others should focus on the place and potential tourist experiences, with reference to the film, rather than focused on the film (Croy, 2010). These promoted credible sources are tools to not only to create awareness, and a more familiar destination image, though more importantly to manage potential tourists' expectation building process (Smith and Croy, 2005; Moyle and Croy, 2009). With the further exposures, through a range of sources, the image will become complex, and complex enough upon which to base a decision to visit or not (Croy and Wheeler, 2007; Croy, 2010). As noted, the ability to make the decision will also be based upon other barriers as well, and the higher the perceived risk of the decision, it is very unlikely the film alone will be enough to base a travel decision (Croy, 2010; Croy and Heitmann, 2011).

The above considerations are much easier to implement for an unknown destination. Unknown destinations also have a much greater chance to show a relationship between film and visitation (Croy and Heitmann, 2011). Raising awareness through film, and the following tourist demand could also be attributed to the film. If a destination is known, then the image management effort needs to also align the potential tourists' existing image to that of the destination's ideal image (Croy, 2010). Depending on the existing image, this could be a very difficult process, and can also be a very difficult process to identify the specific impacts of a film.

In the efforts to connect film to the destination, and manage the image and potential tourist expectations, it is implied that film is only one component of the image management strategy (Croy, 2010). It is also implied that film should be a component, to piggyback on the film production and distribution companies' marketing efforts and the inherent interest in films (Croy, 2010). As film is not a strong attractor on its own, the destination management organisation should use film interest to expose potential tourist to the range of experiences available at the destination. The hopeful consequence is that whilst film plays a role to create awareness, and induce a search for further information, it is the more holistic destination that attracts and provides the experiences

to the tourists. In this context, film plays subtle though crucial roles to generate tourism interest, though the ability to attribute economic contributions to the films specifically is very difficult. Often, tourists will recall seeing a film, and even link it to the destination (Riley *et al.*, 1998; Croy, 2010), though will not always attribute their visit to that awareness and interest creating moment. Furthermore, to exemplify the potential of sustained impact, we often have very potent memories of films, lasting decades. Whilst we may not visit a filmed place immediately, even many years later we can still associate the film with destination, even if not attribute part of the destination inducing image to the film. Film has the potential to have a sustained influence on the image and interest in a place, and have many years of PPEs.

In conclusion, film tourism has increased in its academic popularity, and these studies have shown the wide scope of film influence in tourism. The influence is in functional and critical themes, which has raised the question as to the potential of film to functionally contribute to sustained economic growth. Film has great potential to contribute economically to a destination, during production. The potential of film to contribute through PPEs is less clear. Conclusions are that in exceptional circumstances film-induced tourism can be a sustained economic contributor. All the same, the focus on film-induced tourism underplays the significant roles of film in tourist awareness, image formation, and decision making. Whilst these roles have subtle influences on tourists, they can also be very powerful. These influences should be directed to align the audience's destination image and expectations to that of the community's desired image. How easy or complex this process is will depend on the pre-existing image and the difference to the desired image. The subtle roles of film can provide for a sustained image and interest influence. However, given the subtlety of the roles the ability to measure the PPE economic contributions of film are difficult. Overall, if films exist in a destination, they should be used as a component of the overall image management strategy. Use what the potential tourists already know, and use the film companies' investment in promotion and distribution to generate awareness, to deliver a complex image and expectations aligned to the community's destination. This image management can enhance the opportunities for sustained economic contributions, and importantly enhance the management of undesired impacts of tourism in general.

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